

K.L. RAHUL 31

Right-handed batsman

Test Matches: 63
Runs: 3,789
Avg: 35.41
Highest score 199

Kananur Lokesh Rahul embodies the understated grace of India's batting tradition. His supple wrists and acute judgement outside off stump allow him to adapt across formats and batting positions. In the fierce cauldron of the Test series against England, Rahul reaffirmed his class with 532 runs at an average of 53.20—including two masterful centuries and two crucial half-centuries. He was India's batting metronome—measured in defence, precise in strokeplay. Moreover, it was the manner in which he absorbed pressure and built partnerships that defined his contribution. Rahul's ability to read conditions and guide younger players is a hallmark of his maturity. Also, compared to his modest career average of 35.41, Rahul is clearly in a higher orbit now, vis-a-vis consistency and impact. He was one of only two players in the series to face over 1,000 deliveries, underlining both his patience and resolve.

—Amitabh Srivastava

of the context, the fight and the promise it held. Perhaps the most lasting takeaway was the silence that fell like a blanket over the other side. There was hardly a mention of 'Bazball' all through the summer. England's reckless spirit had been laid bare.

FUTURE READY

As India now gets into white-ball season, marked by the all-important T-20 World Cup early next year, they will do well to keep building on their Test squad for the future. For starters, what place will Jasprit Bumrah hold in it? The biggest match-winner in India's ranks, he has struggled with injuries in the recent past, a bequest of his unusual action. That means India needs to manage his workload carefully or run the risk of losing him for even white-ball cricket. Not having him for two of the three Tests in England did hamper India's plans for the hosts. Perhaps, then, it's time to look beyond Bumrah in the game's longest format. This would allow more clarity when making pre-series plans and also enable Bumrah to operate at his optimum at other international cricket stages.

But this would only be possible if the BCCI can get a pool of pacers that can handle the rigours of five-day cricket, especially in this age of batter-friendly pitches.

The England tour has built an Indian team full of character. It wasn't just a Test series, it was a rite of passage. From boys to men

Not too long ago, under Kohli, India had a pace-pack that was the envy of the world, featuring the likes of Ishant Sharma, Mohammed Shami, Bhuvneshwar Kumar, Umesh Yadav and Jasprit Bumrah. In Siraj, Prasidh, Akash Deep, Arshdeep and, possibly, Mukesh Kumar and Harshit Rana, Gill has the opportunity to recreate such a posse. An uninterrupted run, backed by the team management, is all that is needed.

The next question is over the No. 3 position, and India is still searching for an answer on this. It's a coveted spot held previously by renowned names such as Gundappa Vishwanath, Dilip Vengsarkar, Mohammed Azharuddin, Rahul Dravid and Cheteshwar Pujara. Unfortunately, Karun Nair and Sai Sudharshan have failed to grab the opportunities provided in England. So, does India repose faith in Sudharshan or do they look elsewhere, return to the reasonably successful Sarfaraz Khan perhaps?

India's next series is at home against the West Indies, followed by another domestic two-match series with South Africa, the current World Test Champions—a perfect opportunity to test the applicants. The England tour has built a young team full of character. It wasn't just a Test series, it was a rite of passage. From boys to men. ■